

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

BACKROOM BOYS

A large part of the Congress party's success in 2024 can be attributed to a spirited social media campaign. Despite financial constraints, the party went on an online offensive, often setting the narrative. The turnaround started during the first Bharat Jodo Yatra when the party hired a relatively new agency, Teen Bandar, run by two youngsters, Prashant Chari and Savio Joseph. As for the current surge, two youngsters within the Congress—**Srivatsa Y.B.**, 41, an ex-Youth Congress leader from Karnataka who took charge of Rahul Gandhi's social media channels, and **Vaibhav Walia**, 35, who headed the party's Delhi-based communications war room—could claim some credit. The coordination between the two and other senior party leaders was crucial in getting the right message across to voters.

Making a Point

The Shiv Sena's choice of **Prataprao Jadhav** as their man in the Union cabinet surprised many. Granted, the four-time MP from Buldhana was the seniormost candidate, but speculation was that Maharashtra CM Eknath Shinde's son and former Union minister Shrikant Shinde would be the No. 1 pick for the Modi 3.0 ministry. Shinde has in the past alleged that former boss and Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray promised to make a Sainik the CM but took the chair himself in 2019. Is Shinde then looking to claim the moral high ground after his party's middling performance in the Lok Sabha poll?



THE ANTIDOTE



The induction of first-time Rajya Sabha MP from Assam **Pabitra Margherita** in the Union cabinet is reportedly the BJP's attempt to counter the growing clout of Congress leader Gaurav Gogoi. Both are from the Ahom community, which plays a crucial role in the state's power politics. The community's backing helped Gogoi win the Lok Sabha election from Jorhat despite the best efforts of CM Himanta Biswa Sarma. Margherita, a former cultural activist, is being projected as the BJP's Ahom face. The party will also be banking on his oratory in Parliament, a skill that has earned rival Gogoi a huge fan following among the Assamese youth.



A Voice of His Own

Independent candidate **Umesh Patel's** victory over three-time BJP MP Lalu Patel in Daman & Diu came as a surprise to many. Umesh, a local, is associated with the NGO Daman Youth Action Force (DYAF), and also runs a school. He emerged as a leader in 2017 during the protests against the Gujarat government's moves to merge the UT with the state in a bid to streamline prohibition in the state. He had contested in 2019 too, but success came five years later, making him the first Independent to represent the seat.

Hard Choices Ahead

Now that the general election is over, Telangana CM **A. Revanth Reddy** has his task cut out—fill the six slots left in his six-month-old cabinet. The number of claimants has gone up since, with some communities not represented, as have requests for specific portfolios. Meanwhile, with the Bharatiya Janta Party trouncing the Bharat Rashtra Samithi in the Lok Sabha election, the anticipated drift from the pink party, including some of the 39 BRS legislators in the 119-seat assembly, may not materialise either.



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

Kaushik Deka with Dhaval S. Kulkarni, Amarnath K. Menon and Jumana Shah